

The Impact of US Foreign Assistance Cuts on Chinese Soft Power

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Since Trump's second inauguration, US foreign policy has seen a rapid transformation, including large cuts in US Foreign assistance. This raises the question as to whether foreign aid cuts have weakened American soft power while strengthening China's. Using difference-in-difference regressions across UN Voting alignment and Gallup approval ratings data, alongside sentiment analysis of three case study countries, I find that Chinese soft power has significantly increased since Trump's inauguration but this cannot be attributed to aid cuts.

Foreign Aid | Soft Power | China | USA

On January 20th 2025, Donald Trump was sworn in as the 47th President of the United States. Later that day, he signed an executive order suspending all foreign aid saying that "The United States foreign aid industry and bureaucracy are not aligned with American interests and in many cases antithetical to American values" (1). This came as no surprise, as during his America First campaign he criticized the current world order and promised to reduce American involvement overseas, with foreign aid being a big component of that. While foreign assistance was worth \$72 billion in disbursements in 2024, this became \$47 billion in 2025 and \$6.4 billion as of June 2026 (2). In an August 2025 brief, the White House announced that in an attempt to focus on America First, \$5 billion worth of aid and international organization funding were cancelled as they were deemed "woke, weaponized, and wasteful" and contrary to the goal of America First (3). Yet research shows that foreign assistance is highly effective, with an expected additional 14 million deaths by 2030 as a result of USAID cuts (4). Beyond the humanitarian cost, this withdrawal occurs at a time when the US and China are competing for global influence – and foreign assistance has long been considered a key aspect of soft power. This paper examines whether the impact of American foreign assistance cuts has already influenced global soft power dynamics. Through analyzing UN voting data, Gallup approval ratings and media sentiment in aid-dependent countries, this paper looks at whether Chinese soft power has increased since Trump's second inauguration at the expense of American influence.

1. Relevant Work

USAID and other sources of foreign assistance have traditionally been thought of as integral to American soft power. As coined by Joseph Nye, soft power is "the ability to affect others to obtain the outcomes one wants through attraction and persuasion rather than coercion or payment" (5). Foreign aid in the form of development or humanitarian assistance is integral to soft power and thus strengthening the American image abroad (6). This is supported by Jovan Kurbalija, who describes foreign aid as a "vital instrument" of soft power enabling the USA to foster strong relationships with other countries (7). Foreign aid also enables the USA to shape global policy to become more American-value oriented (8). A study by Blair et al. found evidence that American aid increases support for the USA and strengthens recipients' commitment to liberal democratic values, while Chinese aid does not have the same effect (9). Existing literature is consistent on the importance of foreign assistance for American soft power. Some therefore view the America First platform as "driving people closer to China", in a way which "Makes China Great Again" (10). Yet, existing research has not yet explored whether Trump's aid cuts have weakened American soft power while strengthening China's.

2. Data

2.1 US Foreign Assistance Data. Central to three sections of this study is US Foreign Assistance data. This came from the official United States Government website for foreign assistance (2). Each observation represents a country, the year and the amount of foreign assistance they received from the USA, in both constant (benchmarked to 2024 value) and current dollars. This project uses constant amounts, meaning aid values across years are inflation-adjusted. The dataset spans data from 1946 to 2026 on 247 countries, of which many are overseas territories of other countries, which aren't individual UN member states (e.g. Aruba). The "Transaction Type Name" variable included "Disbursements", "Obligation", "Appropriated and Planned" and "President's Budget Requests". This project focuses on "Disbursements" only, as these are the only transaction type which have actually been transferred to the recipient. After filtering to this

subset of the data, the data ranged from 2001 onward. However, while this dataset provides the total aid received, it doesn't provide context surrounding the size of the recipient's economy. Therefore, I downloaded the World Bank's dataset on current GDP in 2024 dollars (11). It is important to note that the dataset was not updated to include 2025 data, but I assumed that 2024 figures would be relatively similar, so I used the same GDP for both years. The compiled dataset ended in a country-year unit of analysis with aid as a % of GDP.

2.2 UN Voting Data. The second dataset came from the United Nations Digital Library (12) and includes all resolutions that the General Assembly has voted on since 1946 until the end of 2025. However, this investigation focuses on voting patterns post 2000. Each row represents a UN member country, a UN Resolution and how each country voted (Yes, No, Abstain or Absent). This dataset is at the country-resolution unit of analysis. The number of resolutions voted on in a year ranges from 64 in 2013 to 192 in 2025. This is important to note, as both the quantity and the composition of votes differ annually. Dependent on current affairs, certain topics might get more coverage in a given year. Therefore, this might be a confounding factor in this exploration as genuine shifts in alignment might be hidden by the resolution topics.

2.3 Gallup Approval Data. I sourced two additional datasets showing approval ratings of US and Chinese leadership across time from Gallup Analytics (13). They conduct an annual survey asking roughly 1,000 citizens per country across the world for their opinions on certain topics. Data is available from 2006 through 2025, with 2025 seeing responses from 132 countries. Each row of the datasets represents the country surveyed, the year in which the survey was conducted, the approval rate, the disapproval rate and the survey size. This is at the country-year level of analysis. However, the countries surveyed differ each year – a significant number of countries are missing data between 2006 and 2025. This could impact results as it means the dataset has an inconsistent composition.

2.4 Foreign News Headlines. Finally, I used MediaCloud (14) as a database for newspaper headlines in Jordan, Mozambique and Zambia. Due to the time constraint, this study focuses on these countries as case studies that experienced significant cuts in American foreign assistance. For these countries, I collected headlines published by local news networks between January 1st, 2024, and May 28th, 2026, through the MediaCloud API. The data is at the headline level of analysis. The headlines were selected based on whether they included a mention of the USA or China (e.g. "Chinese" or "Washington" etc.), in their local language - Arabic in Jordan, Portuguese in Mozambique and English in Zambia. For each country, I collected 500 headlines related to China, and 500 headlines related to the USA, both before Trump's inauguration and afterwards. Therefore, each country had 2,000 observations, resulting in 6,000 total observations. Of course, the reduced sample size across countries and headlines makes it harder to generalize the results, but they provide interesting findings related to these individual countries.

3. Methods

3.1 Loading and cleaning the UN data. I began by cleaning the UN Voting data to then be able to combine it with the foreign assistance as a % of GDP dataset (01.load_clean). After pulling the "year" from the resolution date, I filtered for resolutions that were voted on after 2000, forming df_post2000. In order to merge the two datasets based on country name, I analyzed the unique UN members in the dataset. I found that some countries had changed names and so the dataset was treating them as separate countries. For example, Turkey had 3 separate entries of "TURKEY", "TÜRKYYE" and "TÜRKİYE". However, the "ms_code" (ms = member state) variable remained consistent regardless of country name. Therefore, I grouped by "ms_code" and filtered for those with more than one country corresponding. Using this, I could write a dictionary of standardized names for each country code, so that I could update the country names in df_post2000 - enabling each country code to have one corresponding name. Next, I cleaned the voting options under "ms_vote" for analysis (Section 4 of the code). I scored the options on a 0-1 scale - Y was recoded to equal 1, while N was recoded to equal 0. I decided to remove all votes where countries were absent, as absences are hard to interpret and could be caused by a multitude of reasons. However, I decided to score abstained votes as 0.5, because they are evidence of a country deliberately refusing to choose a side. Using these values, I created a new variable "ms_vote_score" which mapped the appropriate value for each country and their vote on a specific resolution. To analyze how this alignment compares to that of the US or China, I created two new data frames: "us_votes" and "china_votes". These contained the resolution and the corresponding "us_vote_score" or "china_vote_score". These two variables were then exact merged back onto df_post2000, which now contained the resolution, "ms_vote_score", "us_vote_score" and "china_vote_score". Importantly, I filtered to votes where the US and China were misaligned (i.e. they had a different vote score for the resolution) (Section 6). This was because it would be more indicative of a country aligning themselves more with one than the other. If the US, China and the country of interest all voted the same, it would be hard to distinguish whether that country is more aligned with the US or China. For each resolution, I could now calculate a country's alignment score with the US and China (Section 7). "align_us" and "align_china" are defined as:

$$\text{align_us} = 1 - |\text{ms_vote_score} - \text{us_vote_score}| \quad [1]$$

$$\text{align_china} = 1 - |\text{ms_vote_score} - \text{china_vote_score}| \quad [2]$$

For example, if the two countries were aligned, then the difference between their values becomes 0, and after being subtracted from 1, remains 1, symbolizing perfect alignment. I subsequently removed the US and China's UN votes (as well as Yugoslavia's) as I am interested in other country voting alignment with them as opposed to within themselves, and saved the cleaned data frame as "df_finalized". In total, the dataset ended with 192 individual country codes.

3.2 Loading and cleaning the Foreign Assistance data. To finalize compiling the UN-aid dataset, I analyzed the country codes to see if I could merge the datasets based on them. As mentioned before, the aid dataset had significantly more country inputs than the UN dataset, but I noted that there were 188 countries of overlap. The countries who didn't receive foreign aid were San Marino, Andorra, Liechtenstein and Monaco (all microstates in Europe). To exact merge onto my "df_finalized" data frame, I ensured that the year variables in both data frames were integers, and as the countries were aligned, I was able to left join the aid data onto my overall data frame by "year" and "ms.code". Now, the df_finalized showed each resolution, how the country voted, how that vote aligned with the US & China, and the US aid disbursement for that country in the year in which the resolution was voted on. If there was no record of a disbursement that year, that country received \$0 in the table. To obtain the aid as a % of GDP variable, I uploaded the World Bank's GDP data. To clean the data, I filled years of missing data with the prior year's result. This was predominantly important for 2025, which had no data (Section 10). Like last time, I had to create a similar country name mapping system so that the GDP could be mapped to the appropriate country. I then used a left_join to merge "gdp" onto the df_finalized by country name and year, naming the data frame "alignment_aid_gdp". Two NAs formed, but after further analysis, these were North Korea and Serbia and Montenegro (a state which no longer exists) and so they could be disregarded. Finally, I divided the "aid_disbursement" by the "gdp" variables to gather a new variable: "aid_gdp_ratio". This is the amount of US foreign aid the country received for a given year, as a percentage of their GDP. Therefore, in the fully cleaned dataset (alignment_final), each country x resolution observation corresponds to the year, their alignment scores with the US and China and their aid to GDP ratio for that year. I then exported this as a csv, but as it was too large for Github, I placed it in the shared Google Drive for usage in future scripts.

3.3 Setting up the UN Analysis. In order to gauge whether foreign aid cuts had an impact on Chinese alignment at the UN, I aim to use a difference-in-difference regression technique. To construct this, I needed to first assess what the threshold should be for my treatment vs control ((02_analyze_un, Section 4). I wanted to group countries into whether they received a high or low level of US foreign aid. Looking at the "aid_gdp_ratio" variable, I decided to use the 75th percentile as the cut off for treatment, because aid constituted over 0.5% of these countries' GDP in 2024, and it provided me with 48 countries of treatment, and 144 of control. This is shown in Table 1. I created a new variable, "treated", which assigned a value of 1 for high-aid countries and 0 for the others. I also created another variable called "post" which became equal to 1 if the year was 2025, and 0 otherwise. Finally, I created the interaction term: df['did'] = df['treated'] * df['post'] which became 1 for high-aid 2025 observations, and 0 otherwise. For the regression, I reduced the dataset to one observation per country-year by calculating the average alignment with the US and China for a given country and year. With this, I could then regress "align_china" on the "post", "treated" and "did" terms. I set cov_type='HC3' which deals with the fact that variance might differ across years or countries as opposed to the typical assumption that it doesn't. To determine causality with a DiD, the parallel trends assumption must hold. This would mean that absent of treatment, both aid groups would trend in similar fashion - a key assumption of a DiD. To assess this, I conducted a linear trends test. I calculated the average Chinese alignment each year prior to 2025 for both low and high US Aid recipients and calculated the difference (Section 5). Then, I regressed this gap over time and tested for a slope to see if it was significant. For example, a slope of 0 would mean that the gap doesn't change across time and thus the parallel trends assumption holds.

Table 1. Summary Statistics of the UN Voting x Foreign Assistance Sample.

Statistic	Value
Observations (country-year)	4,915
Years	2000–2025
Countries	192
Treated countries	48
Control countries	144

3.4 Cleaning and preparing the Gallup Approval data for analysis. With the goal of a second DiD regression using approval ratings, I loaded and cleaned Gallup Approval Data in 03_approval_ratings_load_clean. After I loaded in df_clean, the final cleaned script from 01_load_clean, and used the same thresholds to define the "treated" variable, I uploaded the Gallup dataset. Using a common function for both the US and China datasets, I filtered for national aggregate scores, converted "year" to integer type, parsed the percentages into decimals and calculated "net_us" and "net_china" by subtracting the disapproval rate from the approval rate. Once cleaned, the us_approval and china_approval dataframes were at the country-year level, with the associated approval rating, disapproval rating and net rating for the US or China. Combining the two, I used an inner_join on country and year to merge china_approval onto us_approval to created gallup.all (Section 2). As both datasets came from the same source they had the same naming structure. I used an inner_join as I wanted to only have data where there were polls taken for a country's opinion on both the US and China for comparison. I did a second merge where I added the aid data to the gallup.all data frame (Section 4). I chose to do this through an inner_join as well, as I wanted to only retain data where there was a foreign assistance entry from the cleaned dataset and a matching poll for a given country and year. This only dropped 2 countries - Afghanistan and Venezuela - who had no polling data for 2024 (the treatment year). As part of the merge, I once again

created a country name mapping, and dropped polled countries who aren't fully recognized by the UN and thus aren't in my aid dataset. The final cleaned dataset, "gallup_did_clean" contained 42 treatment countries and 112 control countries at the country-year level (Table 2), and was saved as a .csv file to the Google Drive. The dataset was now ready for the DiD analysis, as done in 04_approval_ratings_analysis. Before conducting the DiD, I tested for the parallel trends assumption with the linear trend test. Then, I could regress "approve_china" on the "post", "treatment" and "did" terms.

Table 2. Summary Statistics of the Gallup Approval x Foreign Assistance Sample.

Statistic	Value
Observations (country-year)	2,352
Years	2006–2025
Countries	154
Treated countries	42
Control countries	112

3.5 Collecting and preparing news headline data. My third prong of analysis aimed to see if foreign newspaper headline sentiment saw notable changes in how they portray China and the USA, before and after Trump's inauguration. As mentioned earlier, this section would focus on three countries - selected by analyzing the aid to GDP ratios for 2024 and 2025 and calculating the largest percentage point changes (05_sentiment_load_clean, Section 1). Based on this table, I selected three countries who saw meaningful changes in access to American foreign aid, and had sufficient media available on MediaCloud. For example, the Marshall Islands saw the largest percentage point fall in American aid but has a very small population and thus fewer newspaper sources. Therefore, I chose to analyze Jordan, Mozambique and Zambia. I used an API to gain access to data from MediaCloud and searched for headlines containing mentions of the US or China in English, Portuguese and Arabic (Section 2) between 1st January 2024 and 28th May 2026. For example, the search queries would contain words such as "America" or "chinese". Afterwards, the headlines were preprocessed (Section 3) – for example, headlines with fewer than 5 characters were dropped as junk. Using Ollama's Llama 3 LLM, headlines were denoted as "positive", "negative", or "neutral" through zero-shot classification. Before applying it to my data, I provided it 4 test headlines across 3 languages to test its accuracy. For example, it denoted "China pledges \$1 billion in aid to Zambia" as "positive". I then applied it to the headline dataset and analyzed a sample of the headlines. For example, "Chinese govt will construct 10 milling plants..." was a headline in Zambia and was noted as "Positive". Furthermore, the "TRUMP JUST FROZE \$14 BILLION IN TAIWAN ARMS SALES..." headline was marked as negative, but of course a drawback of Llama is it doesn't have the human subjectivity element. China and other countries across the world might perceive this headline differently. The datasets df_us and df_china were finalized at the headline-level of analysis, with each row containing the country, period (pre/post inauguration), topic (US/China) and the sentiment (e.g. positive). These were uploaded to the Google Drive as df_us_scored and df_china_scored .csv files. In 06_sentiment_analysis, I began my analysis. For each country and period, I calculated the percentage of headlines which were positive, neutral and negative. As part of this, in Section 3, I used a net_sentiment_shift function to calculate net sentiment (Positive - Negative). To gather more specific findings, in 06_sentiment_analysis Section 4, I decided to filter the headlines based on mentions of development in the headline. To do this, I created a list of words related to development across the three languages ("aid", "assistance" etc.). Using a function defined as contains_any, I checked each headline for a mention of a development key word. Of course, this was limited in that many words could be used to write a development-based headline, but I focused on just key ones. Using the headlines and perceived sentiment, I could then create visualizations to see how news sentiment has changed over time.

4. Results

4.1 UN Voting Alignment. As shown in Figure 1, there is a clear shift in voting alignment away from the USA and towards China. The figure shows that average alignment with China jumped from around 0.7 in 2024 to almost 0.9 in 2025. While some of the shift away from the US can be explained by the US seeing a strong pivot in foreign policy and shifting away from others, this doesn't explain the increase in country alignment with China – whose political stances have remained largely constant. To test whether this trend was driven by aid-dependent countries, I compared the high-aid and low-aid groups and their voting alignment over time (Figure 4). The figure shows that both groups had similar trends prior to treatment. To further clarify this, I conducted a linear trend test by testing the significance of the treatment-control gap in the pre-treatment period. This yielded a significant result of 0.001234 (Appendix Table 5). While this means that the parallel trends assumption technically does not hold, the small enough magnitude means that the two groups can be considered as comparable in their pre-treatment trends. The DiD regression found the coefficient on the interaction term to be -0.005 and insignificant (Table 3), meaning that there is no significant relationship between high-aid recipients and a shift towards Chinese alignment. However, the "treated" and "post" variables had positive and significant coefficients at all levels of 0.0267 and 0.0889 respectively. The former suggests that high US aid-dependent countries align with China 2.7 percentage points more than low aid-dependent countries. The latter indicates that Chinese alignment increased by 8.9 percentage points across all countries in 2025 relative to

the 2000-2024 average. Therefore, while there was a clear shift in voting alignment towards China in 2025, this cannot be attributed to changes in American foreign aid.

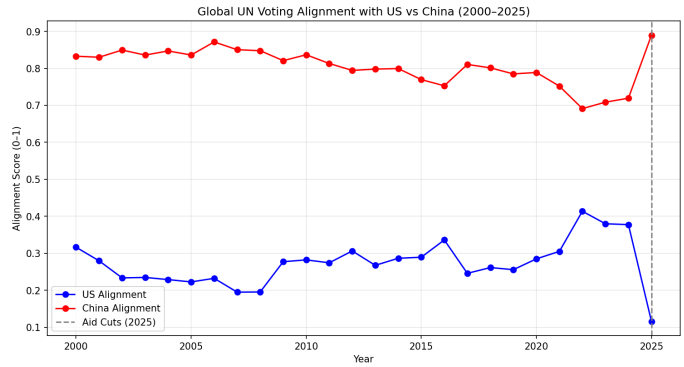


Fig. 1. Average UN voting alignment scores with the US (blue) and China (red), across all UN member states, 2000-2025. Alignment is scored from 0-1, where 1 denotes alignment on all votes. The 2025 aid cuts coincide with a large increase in Chinese alignment and decline in US alignment.

Table 3. DiD Regression - UN Voting Alignment with China.

	China Alignment	US Alignment
Treated	0.0281*** (0.0060)	-0.0411*** (0.0064)
Post	0.0890*** (0.0079)	-0.1645*** (0.0088)
DiD	-0.0054 (0.0194)	0.0161 (0.0215)
R^2	0.017	0.040
N	4,915	4,915

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.2 Gallup Approval Ratings. Global approval ratings of Chinese and American leadership yielded similar findings. Figure 2 shows global averages of both country leadership from 2006 through 2025. While American approval clearly dipped in 2025, Chinese approval saw an increase.



Fig. 2. Annual average global approval ratings of US (blue) and China (red) leadership. While American leadership saw a fall in approval in 2025, China saw an increase - in line with the last 4 years.

To test whether American aid-dependence had an impact on these findings, I first conducted a linear trend test to see if the parallel trends assumption held. Appendix Table 6 found a significant slope of -0.005386 meaning the parallel trends assumption once again does not hold. However, the magnitude of the slope means it is reasonable to assume that the two groups moved relatively similarly in the years prior to treatment (as shown in Figure 5). The DiD regression yielded an insignificant -0.0266 on the Chinese approval term and a 0.0125 on the Chinese net approval term (Table 4). However, the model did find that US global approval fell by approximately 6.5 percentage points while Chinese approval rose by almost 5 percentage points post treatment across all countries surveyed. Interestingly, the

top 25% of aid recipients on average approve of the US by 14 percentage points more than the lower 75%, while they approve more of China by 17.6 percentage points than the less aid-dependent countries. Once again, this does not provide evidence of Chinese approval strengthening as a result of foreign assistance cuts, but it does show Chinese approval strengthened in 2025 at the expense of the US, and that high-aid dependent countries have higher approval of both countries than low-aid countries.

Table 4. DiD Regression - Gallup Approval Ratings

	US Approval	China Approval	US Net	China Net
Treated	0.1426*** (0.0096)	0.1767*** (0.0091)	0.2603*** (0.0162)	0.2991*** (0.0143)
Post	-0.0652*** (0.0194)	0.0493*** (0.0191)	-0.2202*** (0.0413)	-0.0325 (0.0398)
DiD	0.0049 (0.0380)	-0.0225 (0.0399)	0.0624 (0.0708)	0.0233 (0.0715)
R ²	0.1066	0.1637	0.1115	0.1394
N	2352	2352	2352	2352

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

4.3 News Sentiment. Finally, the sentiment analysis found a range of results. Net positive sentiment related to the US decreased in all three countries: Jordan saw a fall from -31 to -46, Mozambique from -7 to -17 and finally, Zambia from -20 to -36 (Figure 3). Chinese results were more mixed, with the net positive sentiment declining by 7 and 8 points in Jordan and Zambia respectively, but increasing by 11 points in Mozambique. After filtering to headlines related to development (Appendix Figure 6), US sentiment saw huge net swings, with Mozambique and Zambia swinging 71 points and 33 points in the negative direction, while Jordan remained flat. China saw declines in Jordan and Zambia, but a 1 point positive swing in Mozambique. These findings should be interpreted cautiously as the sentiment analysis relies on zero-shot classification, the sample size is limited to 500 observations, and the development filter further reduces the sample size. That being said, these case studies do provide evidence of media sentiment becoming more negative towards the USA since Trump's inauguration.

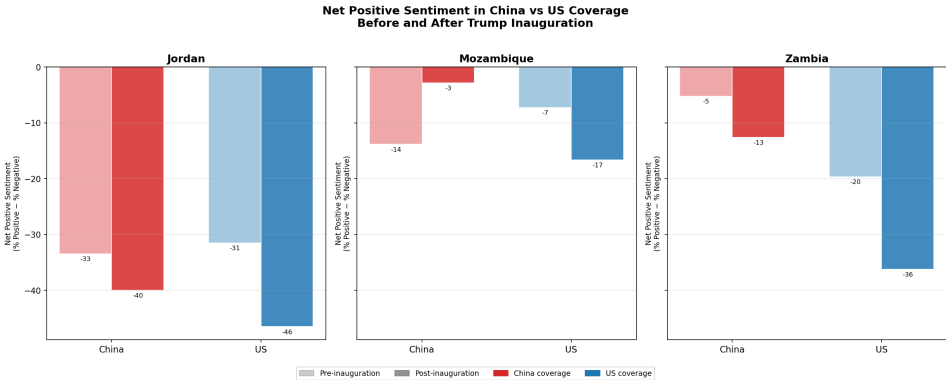


Fig. 3. Net positive sentiment in headlines related to China (red) and US (blue) before (lighter) and after (darker) Trump's inauguration. Chinese sentiment varied - becoming more negative in Jordan and Zambia, while becoming more positive in Mozambique. American sentiment became more negative in all 3.

Discussion

This research has found that US soft power has declined and China's has increased since Trump's second inauguration, but this cannot be attributed to cuts in foreign assistance. In the two DiD regressions, China saw improvement across the treatment and control groups, symbolizing a global shift towards China. This suggests that broader shifts in US Foreign Policy, not just aid reductions, have encouraged countries to shift from the US and towards China.

Several limitations should be noted. Trump's inauguration was only 18 months ago, and so I only had access to roughly 1 year's worth of post-treatment data. It would be interesting to conduct this research further down the line when the full-scale impacts of foreign assistance cuts are felt, and this potentially might be shown in soft power measures. Future research should also aim to implement controls related to other foreign policy measures (e.g. tariffs), to fully isolate the aid effect. Secondly, the sentiment analysis section relied on zero-shot classification which removes human subjectivity on how a headline might be interpreted and its relevance to soft power. The classifications also resulted in broadly similar but different findings every time I ran the code, raising the question of its accuracy. Finally, the sentiment analysis was limited in the number of countries, headlines and development-related headlines it analyzed. Future research should aim to expand these sample sizes to gather more tangible and interpretable findings.

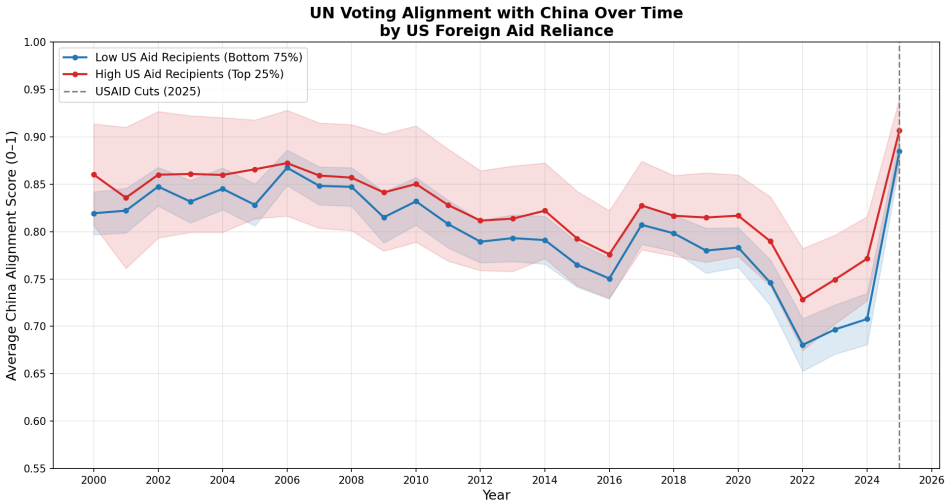


Fig. 4. Pre-treatment parallel trends of both aid groups and average voting alignment with China at the UN. Split by level of American aid received, both high and low aid recipients move in relatively similar fashion prior to treatment and both saw a substantial increase in alignment in 2025.

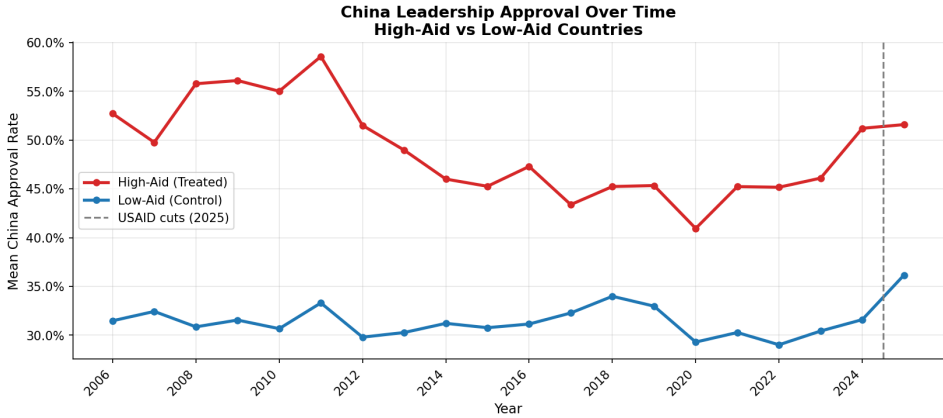


Fig. 5. Pre-treatment parallel trends of both aid groups and mean China approval rating. While high-aid countries saw more variability prior to treatment, both groups moved in relatively similar fashion and saw increases post treatment. Low-aid countries saw a starker increase than high-aid countries

Table 5. Parallel Trends Linear Test — UN Voting Alignment

Statistic	Value
Slope	0.001234
Std. Error	0.000321
R	0.6258
p-value	0.0008
Significant ($p < 0.05$)	Yes

Table 6. Parallel Trends Linear Test — Approval Ratings

Statistic	Value
Slope	-0.005386
Std. Error	0.001617
R	-0.6284
p-value	0.0040
Significant ($p < 0.05$)	Yes

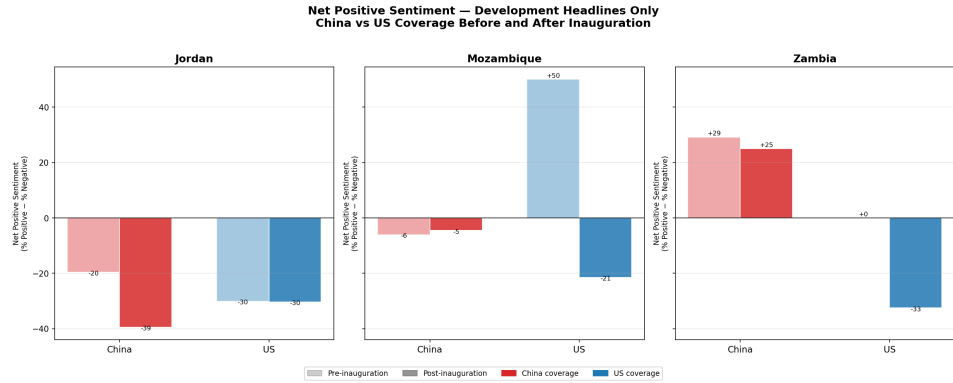


Fig. 6. Net positive sentiment in development-related headlines related to China (red) and US (blue) before (lighter) and after (darker) Trump's inauguration. Chinese sentiment varied - worsening in Jordan and Zambia, while strengthening slightly in Mozambique. American sentiment worsened heavily in Mozambique and Zambia while remaining relatively flat in Jordan.

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AI Reflection

I found AI to be very helpful during this project. After the tutorial video that Professor Chang sent us, I was able to start using Claude Code. This was incredibly helpful for my coding because it enabled me to conduct analysis much quicker than otherwise. This was especially useful earlier on in the project where I was exploring many different ways of presenting the data and so I could have Claude Code create many of these visualizations so that I could get a quick gauge of the data. I gave Claude access to my Pandas scripts and would tell Claude what visualization I would like to see. I would provide further instructions about how specifically the dataset might need to be cleaned. Once Claude had generated the output table or the visualization, I would go through the steps that it took to make sure it aligned with what I was thinking. I also found Claude helpful to implement actions across multiple notebooks at a time. For example, I asked Claude to split notebooks based on loading data vs analyzing data, or I asked it to use the exact same DiD technique across multiple notebooks. When there were moments I was stuck on the code (e.g. I wasn't sure if the Gallup and aid country names were mapping properly) I asked Claude to explore the situation. To ensure the situation was remedied I asked Claude to check the unique countries in each set and which ones were missing from the other. There were some situations where I had to correct Claude. Firstly, it joined the aid data onto the Gallup data incorrectly. It only joined the 2024 aid/GDP data for treatment countries onto the dataset, and did 0 otherwise. I asked Claude to correct it, and it did. Furthermore, on the join types, I would ask Claude why they used that join, and then change it if I deemed necessary. I also noticed some issues with visualizations e.g. one graph had years to one decimal point so I asked Claude to change that. Overall, I learnt a lot using Claude for the coding aspect of this project and it certainly made the data analysis section a lot more efficient. It also taught me that it is important to double check and ask Claude questions as to why it did something the way it did. I also found Github much easier to navigate with the help of Claude, when it came to pushing items onto the depository. For example, after I wrote the ReadMe I asked Claude to embed hyperlinks of the code/output.

I had Claude generate a transcript of our chat as a document (qss20_chat.transcript). It is more of a summary as Claude code removes chats once the chat is full. It wouldn't let me copy and paste the whole thing - only tiny sections. As a result, I learnt that I should ask Claude to create a running transcript. This is what I did for the website creation which I will also upload(website.transcript.claude).

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